Memories of My Father

As I remember Father as a child, he was a wonderful father to me. As I grew older he was more wonderful. Father was loving and kind to us, but at the same time he was stern with us children. When he told us to do something, we knew he meant it.

He moved from Utah to Sunset as it was called then (a place between Winslow and Joseph City, Arizona). They lived in the United Order. Then he took his families and moved to Colonia Diaz, Chihuahua, Mexico. There our oldest sister, Edna, was born January 13, 1887 - the first white child that was born in Colonia Diaz. My brother, John Alexander was born Nov.11,1988 here.

Father pioneered all of his life. He then moved to Pacheco, Chichuahua, Mexico. I was born here the 13th day of June 1891. Then before I was a year old, he moved to Colonia Oaxaca, Sonora, Mexico. He took a farm on the Bavispi River. They raised all kinds of vegetables and grains. We used to grate potatoes to make starch. Father was a good provider. We always had plenty of milk, butter and cheese. They made their own butter and cheese.

When we were small children at Oaxaca, father worked quite a bit at a Ranch between Colonia Juarez and Oaxaca. He came home just before christmas as I remember.

We always knew when Father was coming home. He always blew his nose horn as we called it. It had quite a whistle to it. He had a Santa Clause mask on and us little ones had never seen one before, we all broke and ran because we were scared to death. Father brought Ada and me a set of little china dishes. The cups just fit our finger like a thimble. We thought they were the cutest things we ever saw.

When I was about ten years old, they were settling another town about 28 miles below Oaxaca. They called it Colonia Morelos, Sonora, Mexico. We moved there.

The first thing Father did when we moved to a place was dig a well so that we could have water. There he took up new farms and went to farming again.

All of us children that were big enough would help harvest potatoes, peanuts, and strip cane to make molasses. We would make swords out of mesquite or cotton wood limbs to strip the cane. We would cut all the leaves off then they would cut the cane and haul it to the mill. They would grind all the juice out of the cane and put it in bug vats and cook it until it was a thick syrup. Father made some of the best molasses. The last batch he made, he would leave some of it in the vat then he would put green corn in it and cook it to make candy too. He would invite the whole town and what a jolly time we would have.

Our farm was about four miles from town. Everybody raised watermellons. What a time we would have on hay rack rides with watermellon busts. The farms were all along the Bavispi River in Colonia Morelos.

In the year about 1905, there was a cloud burst up above Oaxaca. It washed the town all away in Oaxaca except about two houses the the school house. Everyone got out without loosing a life. There were pigs, chickens on

the roof tops as they came floating by. They all stayed in the school house. By the time it got down to Morelos, it had calmed down some, but it washed all the farms away and just left big sand mounds. It changed the course of the river bed. It left our home right on the bank. They had to secure the bank with barbed wire and cotton wood limbs.

Father had many friends among the Mexican people. He could rattle the Maexican language off like they did. They called him Santiego Rey.

After the farms were all washed away, they all took farms higher up on the Bavispi Creek. There they raised wheat and oats. We girls, Chloe, Ada, and I would go with Father while they thrashed the wheat and cook for the thrashers on a campfire a week at a time. We all enjoyed it.

Father had a penetrating voice. He would just talk in his natural way and you could hear it way off. One day Chloe and I were up town when he came from work. He said, "Oh Chloe, Come open the gate." We heard him up town.

Father never held feelings. He always forgave anyone of their mistakes.

In 1912, the Mexican War broke out and out Church authorities and the U.S. Government advised us to leave. We left everything we owned behind and never went back. The U.S. Government furnished tents and some provisions for all. They pitched the tents like a town. The people would come out from Douglas in crouds and go up and down the rows of tents to see what they could see.

Father and Ada were standing out by the tent when some people came by and Ada grabbed a handfull of dirt and threw on them. They acted like we were a circus. We were all Mormons. I guess they thought they would see horns on us as they believed the Mormon people had. I had been married almost four years at this time.

Just before we left, there was a special priesthood meeting held. Bishop Charles W. Lillywhite asked some of the brethern to stay. a special prayer was offered and asked for protection. After getting out of town, we could see the red army on the other side of the Bavispi Creek. There hadn't been any storm but the Bavispi Creek was running full from bank to bank. So the red army turned and left. That is the way the Lord protected us.

We left Mexico August 12, 1912; landed in Douglas, then went to Tucson and stayed there for awhile. Father went to Chandler and bought a farm.

He was a lover of horses. He had some of the most beautiful horses you ever saw. After they went to Chandler, he would hitch his pretty horses to his buggy and put the smaller children in the buggy and away they would go to the state fair in Phoenix.

After we left Tucson, I never saw much of father. I was married and had two children - Thora and Ray. When they were little, they used to stand by Father's knees and sing to him. They would sing "Jesus Wants Me For A Sunbeam" and "Hark, Listen To The Classmate Song". We went to the mountains to a little place called pinedale, near Snowflake, Arizona.

Father would be happy if he could see his posterity now.

Della Ray Webb

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